

n8n Automation Example

If/Else Logic with Google Workspace

Beginner to intermediate | Includes subscription & native AI info

n8n

Open-source automation tool | cloud.n8n.io | Self-host for free or use the cloud

What Is n8n?

n8n is an open-source automation tool - meaning anyone can download and run it on their own computer or server for free with no usage limits. For VAs who don't want to manage their own server, n8n also offers a paid cloud version at cloud.n8n.io. The interface uses a visual canvas similar to Make - you connect nodes (steps) with lines.

n8n is more powerful and more technical than Make or ActivePieces. It is a good step up once you are comfortable with basic automations and want more control.

Key Concepts

Workflow

One complete automation. Same idea as a Scenario in Make or a Flow in ActivePieces.

Node

One step inside a workflow - e.g. a Google Sheets node, a Gmail node, an IF node. Same idea as a Module in Make.

Execution

One run of a workflow. Same idea as an Operation (Make) or Task (ActivePieces). Cloud plans have monthly limits.

IF Node

The if/else node. Has two output paths: TRUE and FALSE. Works like Make's Router or ActivePieces' Branch.

Switch Node

An advanced version of the IF node. Lets you create more than two paths - one for each possible value.

Trigger

The first node in every workflow. Defines what event starts the automation.

Subscriptions

Plan	Cost	What you get	If/Else?
Self-hosted	\$0	Unlimited workflows, unlimited executions, all nodes included. Requires setting up your own server - not recommended for VAs.	YES
Starter Cloud	\$20/mo	2,500 executions/month, 5 active workflows, access to all integrations including Google Workspace n8n connector.	YES
Pro Cloud	\$50/mo	10,000 executions/month, 15 active workflows, version history, custom variables	YES

Enterprise	Custom	Unlimited everything, SSO, on-premise option, SLA support	YES
------------	--------	---	-----

Watch out: The n8n Cloud free trial lasts 14 days. After that, you must be on a paid plan to keep your workflows running in the cloud. If you want a free option with no time limit, you need to self-host - which requires technical setup. For VAs who want free automation with if/else, Make (free) or ActivePieces (free) are easier starting points.

Native AI in n8n

Native AI: n8n has an AI Assistant that helps you build workflows by describing what you want in plain language. It is available on paid cloud plans (Starter and above). n8n also has a built-in AI Agent node (powered by LangChain) that can reason through tasks, use tools, and chain multiple AI calls together - more advanced than what Make or ActivePieces offer. Like the other tools, adding OpenAI, Anthropic, or other AI models as nodes requires your own API key, billed directly by the AI provider. To use the AI Assistant on a paid plan: open any workflow and look for the AI chat icon in the top right corner of the canvas.

Automation Example — Lead Budget Router



When a new lead is added to a Google Sheet, check their estimated budget. If the budget is high, email the senior account manager. If the budget is low, email the VA assigned to handle smaller accounts.

What This Automation Does

Condition	Action
Budget column = "High"	Send Gmail to senior account manager with lead details
Budget column = "Low"	Send Gmail to junior VA with lead details

Note: This is the same if/else shape as the other tool examples, shown here in n8n's interface. The logic is identical - only the tool and terminology differ.

Before You Start

- 1 Go to **cloud.n8n.io** and sign up for the 14-day free trial
Use your Google account for fastest signup. No credit card required for the trial.
- 2 Create a Google Sheet called **Lead Tracker** with these column headers in Row 1: Name | Budget | Email | VA Name
Budget values should be exactly "High" or "Low" (capital first letter) - the IF node will match against these exactly.

3

Add two test rows: Row 2: Alex Chen | High | alex@example.com | Sarah Row 3: Jamie Lee | Low | jamie@example.com | Sarah

Part 1 - Create the Workflow

1

From the n8n dashboard, click **New Workflow** (top right or center button)

2

You will see a blank canvas with a single node in the center labeled "When clicking Test workflow" - ignore this for now

This is n8n's manual test trigger. You will replace it with a real trigger in the next step.

3

Click the + icon to the right of the default node to add your first real node

In n8n, nodes connect left to right. The flow reads left to right across the canvas.

Part 2 - Set Up the Trigger

1

In the node search panel, type **Google Sheets** and select it

2

Under "Select a trigger", choose **Row Added**

This fires every time a new row appears in your spreadsheet.

3

Click **Credential for Google Sheets API** - click **Create New Credential**

n8n connects to Google via OAuth. A Google sign-in window will open. Select your work account and click Allow.

4

Under **Document**, click the dropdown and select your **Lead Tracker** spreadsheet

If it doesn't appear, click "Refresh list" or paste the spreadsheet URL directly into the field.

5

Under **Sheet**, select the sheet tab (usually Sheet1)

6

Click **Save** in the top right of the node panel

Part 3 - Add the IF Node (the If/Else)

1

Click the + to the right of the Google Sheets node to add the next node

2

Search for **IF** and select it - it is listed under the Core category

The IF node is always free. It is a built-in n8n tool, not an app integration.

3

In the IF node panel, click **Add condition**

4

Set the condition:

First field: click "Add Value" - in the panel that opens on the left, find your Google Sheets data and select the Budget column. Operator: select "Equal". Second field: type High (with a capital H).

5

Click **Save**

The IF node now shows two outputs: TRUE (when Budget equals High) and FALSE (everything else).

Part 4 - TRUE Path: High Budget - Email Senior Manager

1

Click the + on the **TRUE** output of the IF node

The TRUE output is on the top right of the IF node. FALSE is on the bottom right.

- 2 Search for **Gmail** and select it - choose **Send Email** as the action
- 3 Connect your Google account credential (same process as before - click Create New Credential if needed)
- 4 Fill in the email fields:
To: your senior account manager's email address. Subject: click "Add Expression" - type: New HIGH budget lead: then select the Name column from the left panel. Message: type your message and insert the Name, Email, and Budget fields from the left panel.
- 5 Click **Save**

Part 5 - FALSE Path: Low Budget - Email VA

- 1 Click the **+** on the **FALSE** output of the IF node
Everything that is NOT "High" - including "Low" and any other value - goes down the FALSE path.
- 2 Search for **Gmail** - select **Send Email**
- 3 Use the same credential. Fill in:
To: the VA's email address. Subject: New lead assigned - insert Name from the left panel. Message: include Name, Email, Budget from the data panel.
- 4 Click **Save**

Part 6 - Test and Activate

- 1 Click **Test workflow** (top center button)
n8n will run the workflow using the data in your sheet. It processes existing rows as a test.
- 2 Watch the canvas - each node lights up green as it runs. Check for any red error nodes.
If a node turns red, click on it to see the error message. Most common issue: Google credential not connected.
- 3 Check Gmail - you should have received two emails: one for the High budget lead, one for the Low budget lead
- 4 Click the **Inactive** toggle at the top right of the canvas to switch it to **Active**
Once Active, the workflow watches your sheet automatically and runs whenever a new row is added.

Tip: n8n shows you the exact data flowing through each node during a test run. Click any node after testing to see the input data it received and the output it produced. This makes it much easier to debug than Make or ActivePieces.

Practice: Change the condition from Budget = "High" to a different column. What if you checked the Source column instead? If Source = "Referral" - email one person. If Source = "Cold Outreach" - email someone else. The shape is the same - only the column and values change.

How n8n Compares to Make and ActivePieces

	n8n	Make	ActivePieces
Free option	Self-host only (technical)	Yes - 2 scenarios	Yes - unlimited flows
Cloud free tier	No (14-day trial only)	Yes - 1,000 ops/month	Yes - 1,000 tasks/month
If/else on free	Self-host only	YES	YES
Paid starts at	\$20/month (cloud)	\$9/month	Varies
AI builder	Paid plans (Starter+)	Paid plans (Core+)	None
AI Agent node	YES (advanced)	No	No
Best for	Advanced flows, devs, power users	Simple multi-step flows	Beginners, tight budget

Note: n8n is the most powerful of the three tools but also the least beginner-friendly and the most expensive for cloud use. Recommend Make or ActivePieces for VAs starting out. Introduce n8n once they are comfortable with if/else logic and want to build more complex flows.